MR. LIFE MANAGER · FREE GUIDE

# Laundry, Solved

Sorting, settings, stains, and the step everyone actually skips.

## 01 Sorting

2 minutes

Most people either sort into seven piles or don't sort at all. Neither works. Here's the honest minimum.

### THREE PILES IS ENOUGH

| PILE | WHAT GOES IN | WASH |
|---|---|---|
| **Darks** | Black, navy, dark gray, most jeans | Cold |
| **Lights & colors** | Everything mid-range — most of your clothes | Cold |
| **Whites & towels** | White cotton, towels, sheets, socks, underwear | Warm or hot |

### PULL THESE OUT SEPARATELY

- **Anything brand new and deeply colored** — wash it alone the first time. Red and dark denim bleed.
- **Anything genuinely filthy** — don't put mud or grease in with everything else.
- **Delicates** — bras, anything lacy, anything thin. Mesh bag, cold, gentle.
- **Lint-makers with lint-catchers** — new towels shed onto dark clothes.

> ### WHY COLD FOR ALMOST EVERYTHING
>
> Modern detergent works fine in cold water. Hot sets stains, shrinks things, and fades colors faster. Save warm and... hot for towels, sheets, underwear, and anything someone was sick in — where you actually want the heat.

## 02 Settings, in plain English

| DIAL SAYS | USE IT FOR |
|---|---|
| **Normal / Regular** | **Almost everything.** This is the default and it's fine. |
| **Heavy Duty** | Towels, sheets, work clothes, genuinely dirty things |
| **Delicate / Gentle** | Anything thin, lacy, or that you're nervous about |
| **Quick / Express** | A small load that isn't very dirty. Not a substitute for a real wash. |
| **Spin speed** | Higher = drier coming out = less dryer time. Lower is gentler. |

> ### IF YOU REMEMBER ONE THING
>
> **Normal, cold, and don't overfill.** That handles the overwhelming majority of laundry correctly. Everything else on... this page is refinement.

## 03 Detergent — you're using too much

This is the single most common mistake, and it's the one that makes clothes feel stiff, look dingy, and hold smells.

- **Fill to the line, not the top.** The cap is much bigger than a dose. Look for the marking inside it.
- **A normal load needs roughly two tablespoons** of liquid detergent. Genuinely. Not a full cap.

- **High-efficiency machines need less again** — if the machine says HE, use HE detergent and half of what feels right.
- **Pods: one for a normal load.** Two only if the drum is actually full. Put it in the drum first, not the dispenser.
- **Fabric softener is optional and mostly does harm** — it coats towels so they stop absorbing, and it builds up in the machine. Wool dryer balls do the same job better.

> **WHY TOO MUCH IS WORSE THAN TOO LITTLE**
>
> Extra detergent doesn't rinse out. It stays in the fabric, attracts dirt, traps odor, and makes everything feel scratchy.... If your clothes come out stiff or your towels smell musty after a day, you're almost certainly overdosing — run a load

## 04 Stains

One rule matters far more than any technique.

> **THE ONLY RULE THAT REALLY MATTERS**
>
> **Treat it now, and don't put it in the dryer until the stain is gone.** Heat sets a stain permanently. A stain you've washed and dried twice is usually there forever — so check before it goes in the dryer, every time.

### WHAT TO DO, IN ORDER

- **Blot, don't rub.** Rubbing pushes it deeper and spreads it.
- **Cold water first**, from the back of the fabric, pushing the stain out rather than through.
- **A drop of dish soap** works on most food and grease. Work it in gently, leave it a few minutes.
- **Stain remover if you have it**, then wash normally in cold.
- **Check before drying.** Still there? Repeat. Do not dry it.

| STAIN | START WITH |
|---|---|
| **Food, grease, oil** | Dish soap — it's designed for exactly this |
| **Coffee, tea, juice** | Cold water immediately, then stain remover |
| **Red wine** | Cold water and blot hard, fast. Salt helps while it's wet. |
| **Blood** | **Cold only.** Hot water cooks it in permanently. |
| **Sweat marks on white** | Oxygen-based stain remover, soak before washing |
| **Ink, marker** | Rubbing alcohol on a cloth underneath, blot from the back |
| **Deodorant streaks** | Rub the fabric against itself, or a dry cloth. Usually just comes off. |

## 05 Care labels, decoded

| LABEL SAYS | WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE |
|---|---|
| **Machine wash cold** | Normal cycle, cold. You're fine. |

| LABEL SAYS | WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE |
|---|---|
| **Hand wash** | Usually survives a delicate cycle in a mesh bag. Your call. |
| **Dry clean only** | **Believe the label** on anything structured or expensive — suits, coats, lined pieces, most silk. Cheap knit wool is a different bet. |
| **Tumble dry low** | Low heat, and take it out slightly damp |
| **Lay flat to dry** | Sweaters and knits. Hanging them stretches them out permanently. |
| **Do not bleach** | Check your stain remover — some contain it |

> **THE THINGS THAT ACTUALLY SHRINK**
>
> Cotton, wool, and anything labeled "pre-shrunk" but never washed. Heat is what does it — in the wash and especial... in the dryer. If you're unsure about something you care about: cold wash, air dry, once. Then decide.

## 06 The dryer

> **⚠ EVERY SINGLE LOAD**
>
> **Clean the lint trap.** Every load, no exceptions. It's the leading cause of dryer fires and it takes three seconds.

- **Lower heat, longer, is better** for almost everything. High heat is what wears clothes out.
- **Take things out slightly damp** and hang them. Fewer wrinkles, less shrinkage, longer-lasting clothes.
- **Don't overfill.** Things need room to tumble or nothing dries and everything wrinkles.
- **Never dry:** anything with elastic you care about, swimwear, bras, wool sweaters, anything that says lay flat.
- **Wool dryer balls** speed things up and soften without fabric softener. They last years.
- **Taking too long to dry?** That's the lint trap or the vent, not the machine.

## 07 The laundry chair

The real problem

Nearly everyone has one: the chair, or the basket, where clean laundry lives for a week. This is the actual failure point — not the washing.

> **WHY IT HAPPENS**
>
> Washing and drying are *machine* time — you start them and walk away. Folding and putting away is *your* time, and... it's the only part that needs a decision. So it's the part that gets deferred. The chair isn't laziness; it's the one step the

**WHAT FIXES IT**

- **Fold it straight out of the dryer**, while it's warm. Once it's in a basket it has already lost.
- **One load at a time**, start to finish. Three loads washed and none put away is worse than one load done.

- **Don't start a load you can't finish today.** Not in the morning if you're out all evening.
- **Hang what you can** — hanging is faster than folding, and it skips the drawer entirely.
- **Put the hamper where clothes come off**, not down the hall. Every step of distance is a reason to drop it on the floor.

## 08 The rhythm

| WHAT | GOOD ENOUGH | BETTER |
|---|---|---|
| **A load of laundry** | Weekly, set day | Twice weekly, smaller loads |
| **Sheets** | Every 2 weeks | Weekly |
| **Towels** | Every 3–4 uses | — |
| **Clean the washer** | Monthly — hot empty cycle | Monthly |
| **Lint trap** | **Every load** | Every load |

> **PICK A DAY**
>
> Laundry becomes a crisis when it's triggered by running out of clothes. Same day every week, whether the basket i… full or not, and it stops being an event.

## 09 If you use a laundromat

- **Go at an off hour.** Weekday mornings and late evenings. Weekend afternoons are the worst.
- **Bring everything** — detergent, quarters or a card, a book. Sort at home so you're not doing it there.
- **Multiple machines at once** turns three hours into one.
- **Wipe the drum before loading.** You don't know what was in there.
- **Don't leave it unattended** in the dryer, and set a timer — people will take your things out.
- **Fold there.** There are tables, and it's the only way the chair problem doesn't follow you home.



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